

# Career Ladder & Promotion Framework

Associate CSM Through Principal / Enterprise CSM

## Purpose

Give every CSM a clear, evidence-based path to the next level. Promotion is scope-based and score-based, not tenure-based, so nobody is promoted into a role they haven't already started operating in.

## The Ladder

Associate / Junior CSM → CSM → Senior CSM → Principal CSM / Enterprise CSM

| Level                      | Book                                                       | Decision Authority                                                        |
|----------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Associate / Junior CSM     | Tier 3/4, or shadow seat on a senior book                  | None independently. Escalates anything ambiguous                          |
| CSM                        | Tier 3, sometimes a slice of Tier 2                        | Runs standard renewals and small in-plan upsells alone                    |
| Senior CSM                 | Tier 2, larger or more complex books                       | Runs QBRs independently, leads cross-functional escalations               |
| Principal / Enterprise CSM | Tier 1 strategic accounts, or a cross-account systems role | Full autonomy on account strategy, expansion, and executive relationships |

At the top of the ladder, two real tracks exist: - **Enterprise CSM** — deepest relationship work, the largest accounts, the person you put in front of a board - **Principal CSM** — the systems-builder, designs the playbook others run, mentors at scale, has a hand in org-level decisions

## Six Core Skill Categories

Every level is scored against the same six categories. The bar changes, not the categories.

1. Account Ownership — health monitoring, renewal, day-to-day management
2. Commercial Acumen — expansion, negotiation, revenue impact
3. Communication & Executive Presence — who they can sit across from and hold their own
4. Strategic Thinking — do they execute, or see the pattern before it's a crisis
5. Cross-Functional Influence — how much other teams trust and loop them in
6. Leadership & Mentoring — what they build in other people, not just their own book

## Skills Matrix by Level

**Associate / Junior CSM** - Account Ownership: runs onboarding and routine check-ins solo, reads a health score correctly - Commercial Acumen: not expected yet, can spot and flag an expansion signal - Communication: comfortable with day-to-day contacts, not yet exec-facing - Strategic Thinking: follows the playbook, knows when something's outside it - Cross-Functional Influence: escalates cleanly, doesn't create noise - Leadership: none expected

**CSM** - Account Ownership: owns a full Tier 3 book independently, no hand-holding on renewals - Commercial Acumen: sources expansion signals reliably, handles small in-plan upsells alone - Communication: runs a QBR with a mid-level stakeholder unsupervised - Strategic Thinking: explains why an account is healthy or at risk, not just the score - Cross-Functional Influence: Support and Implementation loop them in without being asked - Leadership: occasionally helps onboard a new hire informally

**Senior CSM** - Account Ownership: owns Tier 2, sometimes overflow Tier 1, runs saves on real at-risk accounts - Commercial Acumen: has closed or co-closed real expansion revenue, not just sourced it - Communication: runs a QBR with a VP-level stakeholder, handles a tense conversation without escalating it up - Strategic Thinking: flags a churn pattern before it's visible in the numbers - Cross-Functional Influence: has shaped a process other CSMs now use - Leadership: actively mentors 1-2 newer CSMs, scored, not optional

**Principal CSM / Enterprise CSM** - Account Ownership: owns the company's highest-stakes accounts, or the operating model itself - Commercial Acumen: directly responsible for material NRR/expansion outcomes at account or segment level - Communication: runs a room with C-suite stakeholders, represents CS in exec-level conversations - Strategic Thinking: has input into org-level decisions: tiering, segmentation, process design - Cross-Functional Influence: trusted by Product/Sales/Exec leadership as a real voice - Leadership: mentors at scale, or builds the systems others run on

## KPIs by Level

| Level                  | Primary KPIs                                                                                    |
|------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Associate / Junior     | Activation rate, time-to-first-value, ticket resolution quality                                 |
| CSM                    | Book retention rate, health score accuracy, NRR on their book                                   |
| Senior CSM             | NRR/expansion sustained over multiple quarters, save rate on at-risk accounts, QBR quality      |
| Principal / Enterprise | Segment or account-level NRR, expansion revenue directly attributable to them, org-level impact |

A single good quarter never promotes anyone. Every KPI is evaluated across 2-3 consecutive quarters.

## Scoring Model

**Weighted scorecard:** - Account Ownership: 20% - Commercial Acumen: 20% - Communication & Executive Presence: 15% - Strategic Thinking: 15% - Cross-Functional Influence: 15% - Leadership & Mentoring: 15% (redistributed at Associate level, where it isn't scored)

**Scoring scale, 1 to 5 per category:** 1. Below level expectations 2. Meets expectations for current level 3. Consistently exceeds current level 4. Operating at next level informally 5. Fully ready, next level is a formality

**Promotion threshold:** average score of 4+ across all categories, sustained for two consecutive review cycles, with no single category below 3. A high average with one weak category doesn't clear the bar. The gap closes first.

**Who scores it:** - Self-assessment against the matrix - Manager assessment against the same matrix, backed by specific evidence: the save, the expansion, the QBR that held up under pressure - At Senior CSM and above, 360 input from at least one cross-functional partner, since outside influence is a real criterion at that level

**Review cadence:** scored twice a year, evaluated against 2-3 quarters of evidence each cycle.

## Artifacts

- Weighted promotion scorecard (spreadsheet)
- Evidence log per CSM: specific saves, expansions, and QBRs cited against each score
- Semi-annual review calendar